

expectedly slow surface at the R. Premadasa Stadium — the 20-year-old proved that one can be enough when that one is Marufa: fast, strong, light on her feet, and capable of drawing out prodigious swing.

A fan of Australian great Mitchell Starc, Marufa has chosen a fitting role model. Her inswingers to right-handers left Pakistan gasping when she removed Omaima Sohail and the in-form Sidra Amin off successive deliveries, reducing them to ruins in the very first over. The effort drew praise from several leading voices in world cricket, including Sri Lankan legend Lasith Malinga, who posted a clip of her twin strikes with the words: "Pure skill, excellent control. So far, the best delivery in this tournament."

It brought back memories of another two-in-two she produced against Sri Lanka at the 2023 T20 World Cup in South Africa, when she dismissed Vishmi Gunaratna and Anushka Sanjeevani to jolt the chase. That came after removing Chamari Athapaththu in her previous over. She took all three wickets to fall that day, though Bangladesh still fell short.

A more emphatic demonstration of her talent came in Bangladesh's first-ever ODI win over India in 2023, when she returned figures of four for 29, dismissing Smriti Mandhana, Priya Punia, Amanjot Kaur, and Sneha Rana to seal a famous victory.

Smriti, ever generous in praise,

said later: "It doesn't matter what her age is. The kind of effort she is putting in the field, just to watch her with the kind of fire she has in her to be a good cricketer, has been just amazing. Her ball skids a bit more than we expect from her release point. These sorts of wickets (low and slow in Dhaka) aren't helping her much. We'll have to see what she does in England and Australia."

Building power

Back then, Marufa was a wiry teenager who roared at every wicket and hurled herself at the ball in the field. The passion remains, but the foundation has strengthened — built on structured fitness and power training, and technical refinement. That shift came under the guidance of Bangladesh's former strength and conditioning coach Ian Durrant.

"Earlier, I used to bench press 25–30kg. Now I do around 42–44kg, and squats with 30–35kg have now gone up to 60kg," an excited Marufa said in a video shared by the Bangladesh Cricket Board.

She also studies strength in others, taking a particular liking to Pakistan's Diana Baig.

"Her arm is very strong. I love her swing; she can do inswing and outswing," Marufa said after their tussle in Colombo.

The young pacer made a strong early impression, finishing as Bangladesh's top wicket-taker at the 2023 U-19 T20 World Cup and putting in notable performances at

the 2022 Asian Games. Captain Nigar Sultana Joty, who has watched her evolution from behind the stumps, has been among her keenest observers.

"Initially, she didn't think much about her bowling and other elements. I used to be the one helping her with her plans. She has matured since. She now thinks about her own bowling strategy and about her plans in the death, how she needs to attack a left-hander or a good slogger who can find the boundary," Joty told *Sportstar*.

Joty knows the difficulty of keeping that spark alive when everyone wants to refine you.

"We have not seen this sort of player in our country for a long time. She is unique and very special. She is a very hardworking player as well. Her action is different. In Bangladesh, we don't have a player like this who can bowl with the kind of speed she has and manage that kind of swing. She has worked with so many coaches in the past few years now, but the good thing is that they have all let her stay true to her game. They are only polishing what she already is."

From one field to another

There was a time when Marufa's current life seemed a distant dream. Around the pandemic, videos shared by cricketer-turned-coach Arifa Jahan Bithi — who runs Bangladesh's first and only academy for girls, the *Women's Dreamer Cricket Academy*



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For a simple farming family surviving on leased land, Marufa's rise has been life-changing. But what means most to her is the shift in her father's outlook.